

Aga Khan looks to Harvard, MIT for Moslem roots

People who have visited the Tehran Hilton say it's like a space warp. Walking out the door, you can't be quite sure whether you're in Iran or downtown Los Angeles.

That loss of sense of time and place is the result of decades during which the upwardly mobile nations of the Third World have lined up at the sales counters of Western culture to buy their symbols of progress.

In architecture, those symbols have usually been glass and concrete high-rise buildings like those in Tehran. Often they're helplessly unfitted to local climate and lifestyle, to local materials and building methods. They're designed either by American or European architects or by native practitioners who have trained in America or Europe. Not surprisingly, a Houston firm that designs for the Middle East tends to produce a building that looks a lot like Houston. Maybe there are a few arches on the ground floor that are supposed to say "Moslem," but that's often as far as adaptation goes.

None of this was good enough and everyone always knew it, but no one knew

ARCHITECTURE By ROBERT CAMPBELL

what to do about it. But now attitudes are changing. Warmed-over westernization doesn't have the appeal it did. The revolt in Iran of the ayatollahs shows, if nothing else, that people are not so ready to desert their own culture.

It's in the context of all this that the announcement came last week of a huge gift from the Aga Khan, leader of 20 million worldwide Moslems, to Harvard and MIT to create an "Aga Khan Program for Islamic Architecture." Eleven-plus million dollars of the Khan's money will go to bring East and West together in Cambridge, for the purpose of deciding what Islamic architecture should be in the age of OPEC.

The idea seems quixotic at first. Why would anyone expect to find the roots of a new Moslem building tradition in Boston? Isn't the Khan repeating the mistake of looking to the West for all the answers?

But that's too simple an irony. William Porter, dean of the school of architecture

and planning at MIT, who helped plan the program, points out its advantages:

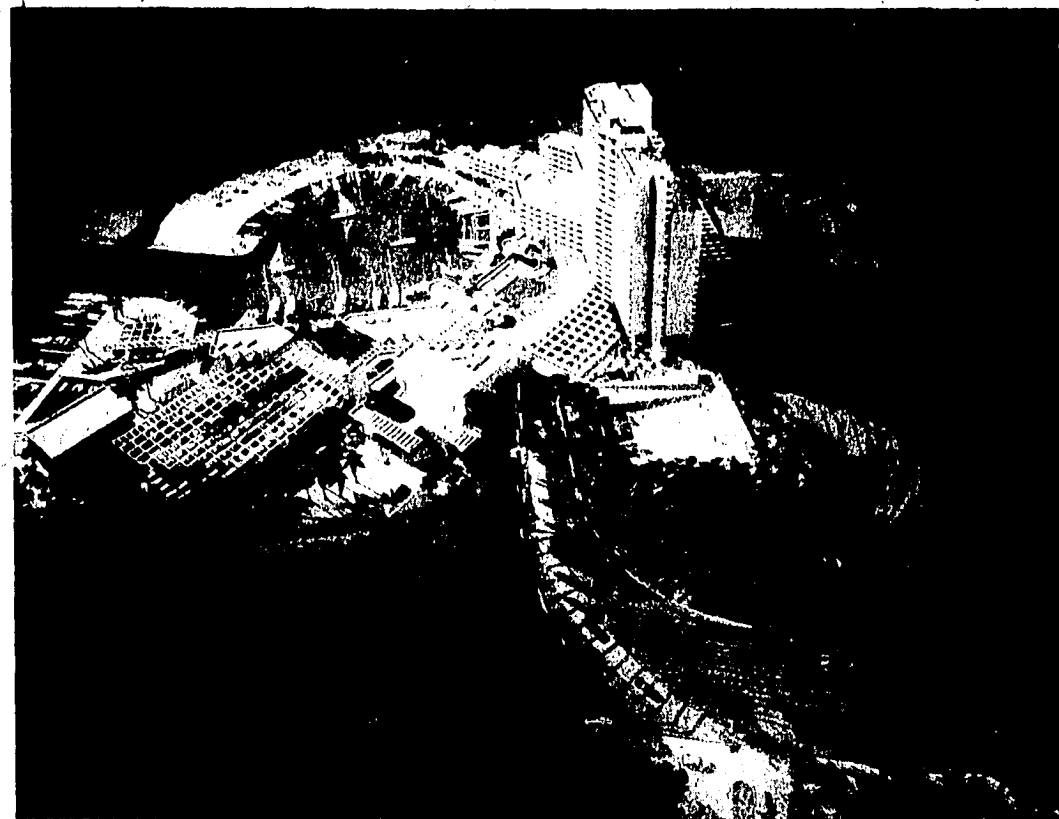
"Awareness of the need for regional roots is a stronger trend in architecture here than in Europe or anywhere else," Porter says. "And we're actually apt to know more here than they do there about their own culture, because we have the centers of information."

The new program will endow professorships at both universities and fund exchanges of professionals between the US and the Near East. Summer institutes in Cambridge will bring together both scholars and practitioners. A documents center will collect and computerize information on Moslem culture and architecture and make it available worldwide.

In announcing the program, the Khan spoke of the "increasingly rapid and ill considered destruction of architectural heritage" in the Islamic world and of "excessive reliance on western styles, ideas, materials and solutions."

The Khan's gift is a byproduct, in a sense, of another project, the "Aga Khan Award for Architecture for Moslem Purposes." These prizes, which at \$100,000 each will about equal the value of Nobel prizes, will be awarded starting in 1980. In helping to plan them, MIT's Porter and Oleg Grabar of Harvard's fine arts department found themselves having difficulties because information on Moslem culture and architecture was scattered and inaccessible. The new program developed from that problem.

At root, the Khan's feeling is no different from the feeling of a New England



Among the western-designed works under construction in the Arab world is this model hotel complex designed by Benjamin Thompson Associates of Cambridge for Abu Dhabi. If not derived from Moslem tradition, it is at least good architecture.

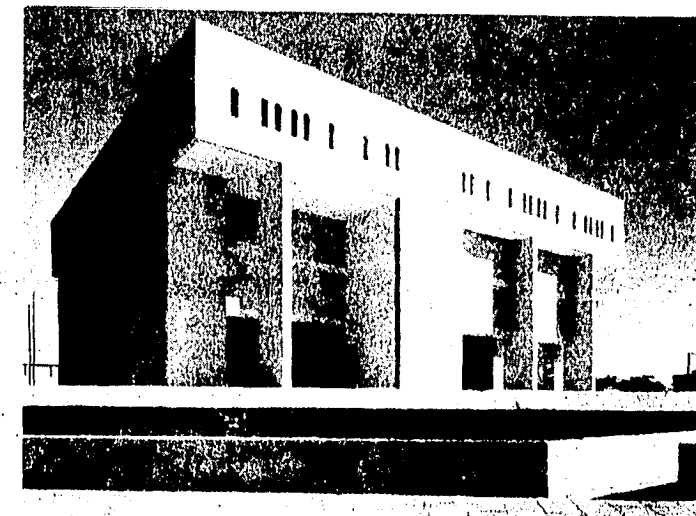
(Steve Rosenthal photo)

town that it doesn't want to look like a California shopping center. Both are part of a worldwide reaction against packaged, homogenized "progress." Both are concerned with preserving regional and cultural difference so as to create a keener sense of place and time.

A "Main Street Management Workshop" is scheduled in Portsmouth May 31-June 1. Sponsored by the US and Greater Portsmouth Chamber of Commerce and the National Trust for Historic Preservation, the workshop will demonstrate how

Main Street can attract people and business to downtown centers. Information is available from the Portsmouth Chamber.

The Boston Architectural Center is offering summer courses in architecture, interior and landscape design, drawing and solar energy. Phone is 536-3170.



Works of Boston area architects are among the best of western designed buildings in the Arab world as, for example, headquarters of Fund for Arab Economic Development in Kuwait designed by Architects Collaborative.

(Wayne Sövers, Jr., photo)